

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> one beat -> drop the pace -> simplest true sentence -> pause -> follow or release. -> "Let me slow that down. The main point is?" -> "I need a beat before I answer." (then answer, slowly) -> "One thing at a time — here's the simple version."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Pause for one beat, drop your pace by a notch, and answer with the simplest true sentence.

BEST FOR

- When pressure makes you rush or talk over people
- When your voice is turning sharp, clipped or defensive
- When a slower first sentence would take the heat out of things
- When you are being pushed for an instant answer and need a beat to give a good one
- In tense meetings, disagreements or hard feedback
- When staying steady matters more than being fast

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Buy-a-beat one-liners

- "Let me slow that down."
- "One thing at a time."
- "Give me a beat."
- "Let me get this right."
- "Hang on — one sec."
- "Let me answer that properly."
- "Short version first."

Warm · Steady, keeps rapport

- "I want to answer that carefully."
- "Let me think about that for a second."
- "That's a fair question — give me a moment."
- "I'd rather get this right than get it fast."
- "Bear with me a second."
- "Let me take that in properly."

Professional · Work / meeting / decisions

- "The main point is?"
- "The simple version is?"
- "Let me take these one at a time."
- "Before I answer, let me make sure I've got the question."
- "I'll give you a clear answer in a moment."
- "Let me separate the two things you asked."
- "Here's where I've landed."

Direct · Firm, clear first sentence

- "Here's the short answer."
- "The main thing is this."
- "Let me be clear and brief."

- "One point, then I'll stop."
- "Straight answer: here it is."
- "I'll say the important part first."

Repair · When it got heated or fast

- "Let me say that more simply."
- "I may be reading this wrong."
- "Let me back up and slow this down."
- "That came out faster than I meant."
- "We can stay with this or move on — your call."
- "Ignore that if it doesn't fit."

High-stakes · Pressure / conflict / put on the spot

- "I hear the urgency. Give me one beat."
- "I want to get this right, not just quick."
- "Let me slow us both down for a second."
- "I'm not dodging — I want to answer it properly."
- "Let me take a breath and answer plainly."
- "One thing at a time, even now."

Digital / text · Written variants

- "Give me a bit to answer this properly."
- "Short version now, fuller version later if useful."
- "I may be reading this wrong, but this seems like the relevant thread."
- "We can stay with this or move on — your call."
- "One thing at a time — let me take the first."
- "Let me come back to this clearly rather than fire off a quick reply."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Answering everything at once, fast and defensive.
Better: One beat, then the simplest true sentence.
Best: One beat, the simplest true sentence, then stop and watch how they take it.
- Weak: "That's wrong." (fast, sharp)
Better: "The simple version is?" (slower, one point)
Best: "I might be reading this wrong, but the simple version is?" (slow, one point, leaves them room)
- Weak: Talking faster to win the moment.
Better: Slowing your first sentence to steady it.
Best: Slowing your first sentence, then pausing so the other person can catch up too.

DECISION TREE

If They add detail

Stay with it at the steadier pace.
"Good — keep going."

If They pause thoughtfully

Wait. Do not rush to fill the silence.

If They look uncomfortable or confused

Release the move — make it smaller or drop it.
"Let me say that more simply."

If They ask for advice

Switch to Permission-Based Advice.
"Want my take, or just a sounding board?"

If Action is genuinely needed now

Stop slowing down and act directly.

"Here's what we do."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Use the smallest version — a single beat before you answer. — "Give me a sec — let me get this right."

Professional / meeting

Keep it concise and non-performative; lead with the main point. — "The main point is the supplier delay. About a week."

Conflict or disagreement

Pair the slowdown with validation or an autonomy release so it doesn't read as stonewalling. — "I hear you. Let me slow down and take the main thing first."

Digital / text

One sentence only; resist firing off a fast reply. — "Let me come back to this properly rather than reply on the fly."

High-stakes / pushed for an instant answer

Give direct clarity first, then slow down only if it lowers the pressure. — "Straight answer: yes. Now let me explain why, slowly."

Hard feedback landing on you

Take one beat before responding so you answer the point, not the sting. — "Let me take that in for a second before I respond."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When physical safety or an emergency needs immediate action, not a pause
- When you would be using the slowdown to dodge accountability or run out the clock
- When the answer is already clear and direct, and slowing it down just adds drag
- When a fast, decisive yes or no is exactly what the moment needs
- When the other person is already calm and the pace is fine as it is

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

List five moments this week where pressure made you speed up. Note the physical tell each time — fast breath, tight chest, talking over someone.

Day 2 — Write the lines

For three of those moments, write the fast, defensive version and the simplest-true-sentence version side by side.

Day 3 — Cut it down

Take your best sentence from Day 2 and reduce it by 30 percent. Say it out loud at a slower pace.

Day 4 — Add the beat

Practise the one-beat pause before speaking. Read each line aloud with a deliberate breath first, then the slow first sentence.

Day 5 — Bank a recovery line

Pick one recovery phrase you'd actually say and rehearse it, so you have it ready when a slowdown lands badly.

Day 6 — Use it live, low-stakes

In one low-pressure conversation, take a beat and lead with a single slow sentence, then stop and watch the response.

Day 7 — Use it under real pressure

In one genuinely pressured moment, notice the rush, drop your pace by a notch, say the simplest true sentence, and release. Note afterwards what changed.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the cue before I sped up?
- Did I lead with one simple true sentence rather than a rush?

- Did I pause and watch the response?
- Did I stop when the energy dropped or the moment needed speed?
- Was I steadying myself, or using the pause to dodge or steer?
- Would a faster, more direct answer actually have been better?